



REGIONAL RELOCATION GUIDE • NEW ZEALAND

Southland

Where you would work, where you would live, and what an ordinary week looks like in Southland.

Ethicare Resourcing

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This guide is free, and so is everything in it. Every chapter here is also on the website, where it is kept up to date — so if you are reading this some months after downloading it, check the site for anything that looks time-sensitive. Fees, tax rates and immigration settings change without much notice.

We don't print these. A PDF costs nothing to send and nothing to ship, which felt like the right answer for a company that spends its days moving people around the world.

Welcome to Southland

Southland Guide · Chapter 1 of 9

Nau mai, haere mai ki Murihiku. Southland is the bottom of the country — a broad green plain running down to a wild coast, with Fiordland at one end, Rakiura across the strait, and the most affordable city in New Zealand in the middle of it.

The last place people look, and one of the best

Southland is the southernmost region in New Zealand, and it is bigger and more varied than most people realise. Invercargill sits near the south coast with around fifty-seven thousand people and the region's base hospital. Gore is an hour north-east through farming country. Te Anau is two hours north-west, on the edge of Fiordland National Park. And Rakiura — Stewart Island — lies an hour by ferry beyond Bluff, almost entirely national park.

The clinical picture here is strong, and this is the part that surprises people. Southland has a base hospital serving the whole region, with a rural network reaching into Fiordland and the western districts. It is real hospital medicine, in a city where a family home costs less than anywhere else in the country.

What it asks of you is a tolerance for weather and distance. This is cool temperate, maritime, often grey and frequently windy. Dunedin is two and a quarter hours away, Queenstown two, Christchurch six. If those two things do not put you off, Southland offers a combination — a base hospital, genuinely affordable housing, and one of the great wildernesses on earth an hour up the road — that almost nowhere else can.

Who wrote this

We're a healthcare recruitment company, so we have an interest — but this guide isn't a pitch. There's nothing in it asking you to register, no form, and no visa advice.

Southland is the region we get asked about least and recommend more often than our enquiry numbers suggest. Where we think it's the wrong answer, we say so.

The region, in nine numbers

~103,000

People across the whole region, in an area larger than Wales.

~57,000

In Invercargill, the southernmost city in New Zealand and one of the southernmost in the world.

1 base hospital

In Invercargill, serving Southland, Fiordland and Rakiura, run by Health New Zealand | Te Whatu Ora, with rural services across the region.

~2 hr 15

To Dunedin, where the region's tertiary care and the medical school sit. Queenstown is around two hours.

Cheapest

City housing in New Zealand. Not "affordable relative to income" — the lowest actual prices of any city in the country.

~10 min

A typical commute across Invercargill. Traffic is not a concept that applies here.

~9.45pm

Sunset in late December. At 46 degrees south the summer evenings are extraordinarily long, and the winter mornings correspondingly dark.

1.2m hectares

Of Fiordland National Park, a World Heritage wilderness beginning about two hours from the city.

Aurora australis

Visible from here on a clear, active night. One of the few inhabited places in the world where that is an ordinary occurrence.

Six things you only learn once you're here

The weather is the price of admission

Cool, changeable and windy, with more grey days than the north and fewer hot ones. Nobody here pretends otherwise. What you get for it is green country, no drought, and nobody else on the trails.

The summer light is astonishing

Light until nearly ten at night in December and January. You will eat outside at nine, and you will do things after work that you could not do anywhere further north.

There is a real accent

The Southland burr — a rolled "r" inherited from Scottish settlers, and the only genuine regional accent in New Zealand. You'll hear it within a day and grow fond of it.

Housing costs almost nothing, comparatively

The single most consequential fact in this guide. A large family home here costs a fraction of an apartment in Queenstown, two hours up the road. [Cost of living](#) spells it out.

Locals defend the place fiercely

Invercargill has spent decades being the butt of other regions' jokes, and Southlanders have long since stopped caring. The community pride here is real and it is welcoming.

Fiordland changes what a weekend is

Milford, Doubtful Sound, the Kepler and Routeburn tracks. Most New Zealanders visit once. You would live two hours away.

A note on names

Murihiku — "the last joint of the tail" — is Southland's name in te reo Māori, and this is the rohe of Ngāi Tahu. Rakiura is Stewart Island; Waihōpai is the river Invercargill sits on. The southern coast has been travelled and harvested for centuries, and tītī — muttonbirding — remains a living customary practice on the islands off Rakiura.

You're not expected to arrive fluent. You are expected to try. [Te ao Māori at work](#) covers pronunciation and the words you'll hear on the ward.

How to read this guide

Nine chapters, all of them about Southland specifically. Anything true of New Zealand generally — visas, registration, tax, renting law, driving licences, schools — lives once in [Moving to New Zealand](#) rather than being repeated here.

If you read nothing else, read [Why Southland](#) for the full case — and what we'd ask you to weigh, and [Cost of living](#), because the numbers here are unlike anywhere else in the country.

Why Southland

Southland Guide · Chapter 2 of 9

Southland gets fewer enquiries than any region in this collection and produces more contented clinicians than most. The gap between those two facts is what this chapter is about.

The arithmetic

Clinical pay in New Zealand is set nationally. You earn the same in Invercargill as in Auckland or Queenstown. What changes is what it costs to live — and here it costs less than anywhere else in the country.

That is not a small difference. Invercargill has the lowest house prices of any New Zealand city, by a clear margin. A large four-bedroom family home on a proper section, ten minutes from the hospital, costs less than a modest apartment in Queenstown two hours north. On a single clinical salary you can buy here almost immediately, and on two you can do it comfortably and still travel.

Set against that: it is a small city a long way from the rest of the country, and the weather is the coolest and greyest in New Zealand. Those are real costs, and they are the reason the housing is cheap. The question is simply whether you would rather pay in money or in latitude.

A typical week

Monday to Friday

Ten minutes to work, and free parking. Invercargill's streets were laid out with an optimism about traffic that never materialised, which is entirely to your benefit.

After work, summer

Light until nearly ten. A beach at Oreti, a round of golf, a bike ride, or the estuary. The long evenings are the region's secret pleasure.

After work, winter

Dark early and often wet. This is when the indoor life matters — and Invercargill has an unusually good stock of pools, gyms, a velodrome and community sport for its size.

Saturday

Bluff for oysters and the walk out to Stirling Point, Riverton for the coast, or the Catlins east along the southern scenic route.

Sunday

Te Anau and the edge of Fiordland, two hours up the road. Or the ferry to Rakiura, where you can hear kiwi in the evening.

A long weekend

Milford or Doubtful Sound, the Kepler Track, Queenstown, Dunedin or the Catlins. It is an extraordinary base for a certain kind of weekend.

The six things people ask us

Is there enough clinical work?

Is the weather really that bad?

Can I actually buy a house?

Is it isolated?

Is it a good place with children?

What is there to do?

Who we'd steer further north

You want warmth and sun

This is the wrong end of the country, plainly. If sunshine hours matter most to you, look at Hawke's Bay, the Bay of Plenty or Nelson.

Your specialty needs tertiary volume

Complex and highly specialised work goes to Dunedin or Christchurch. Southland is a base hospital, not a tertiary centre.

You want a city that feels like a city

Invercargill is a functional, friendly small city. It is not Wellington or Christchurch, and if urban life is central to your happiness, be honest about that.

You need easy international travel

Long-haul means Christchurch, Auckland or a drive to Queenstown. It is the longest travel day of any region in this guide.

You'd find the winter dark hard

At 46 degrees south, midwinter mornings and afternoons are genuinely dark. Some people love the seasonality; others find it wearing, and it is worth knowing which you are.

Where we'd steer you instead

Want the far south with more city and a tertiary hospital? **Dunedin**, two and a quarter hours east.

Want the mountains and lakes, and can absorb the cost? **Central Otago** — though read its cost chapter first.

Want the South Island with real clinical depth and a bigger city? **Christchurch**.

In our experience

Southland gets fewer enquiries than any region we cover and produces more contented clinicians than most — the maths works, the hospital is steady, and Fiordland does the rest. Bring proper clothing and low expectations of the weather; everything else over-delivers.

Southland at a glance

Southland Guide · Chapter 3 of 9



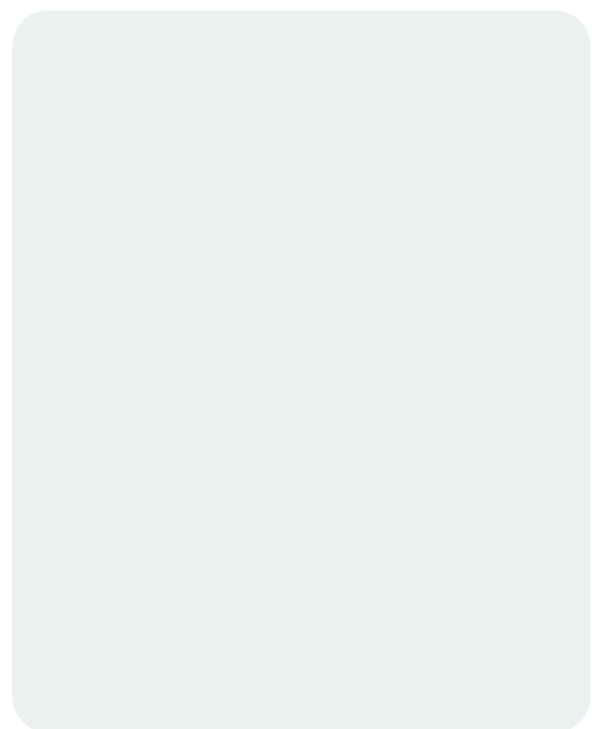
Southland is a broad, intensely green plain, bounded by mountains to the north-west and a wild ocean to the south. Nothing about it is dramatic until you reach the edges – and then it is as dramatic as anywhere on earth.

The shape of the region

The middle of Southland is farmland: the Southland Plains, some of the most productive pasture in the country, running from the Takitimu Mountains down to the sea. Invercargill sits near the southern edge on the Waihōpai River, with the Oreti and New River estuaries beside it and Oreti Beach's long grey sweep to the west.

North-east through the plains is Gore, an hour away, on the Mataura River – a farming and brown-trout town, and the region's second centre. North-west, past Winton and Lumsden, the land climbs into the Te Anau basin and then into **Fiordland**: 1.2 million hectares of World Heritage wilderness, glacial sounds, and some of the highest rainfall on the planet.

South of the city, Bluff sits on its hill above the strait, and an hour by ferry beyond it is **Rakiura** – Stewart Island – eighty-five per cent national park, four hundred people, and one of the best places in the world to see kiwi in the wild. East, the coast runs into the Catlins.



Where Invercargill sits, with the straight-line distance to Gore and Te Anau

The four seasons

Summer

Dec – Feb

18–22°C

Mild, endlessly light

Autumn

Mar – May

14–18°C

Often the best of it

Winter

Jun – Aug

8–11°C

Cool, damp, dark early

Spring

Sep – Nov

12–16°C

Windy. Genuinely windy

Indicative daytime highs. Snow at sea level is uncommon; frost is normal. Inland around Gore and Te Anau the range is wider at both ends.

What the numbers don't tell you

The light is the thing nobody warns you about. At 46 degrees south the summer days are enormous – light from before five in the morning until nearly ten at night around the solstice. It reshapes how you live for four months of the year. The corollary is a genuinely dark midwinter, and it is fair to weigh both.

It is cool rather than cold. Southland's reputation is for grimness, but the maritime climate keeps extremes off: it rarely freezes hard and rarely gets hot. What it does do is change quickly, and blow. Locals dress for four seasons in a day and think nothing of it.

The wind is constant, and spring is the worst of it. A prevailing westerly straight off the Southern Ocean with nothing between here and Antarctica. You will own a good coat within a fortnight.

Houses need to be warm, and increasingly are. The regional housing challenge is heating and damp together. Because homes are cheap here you can afford to buy one that is already well insulated – a genuine advantage over the expensive regions. Check the Healthy Homes compliance statement, which is a legal requirement and covered in the national Renting in New Zealand chapter.

The aurora australis is real and it is visible. On clear, geomagnetically active nights the southern lights appear over the southern horizon. There are local groups who chase it. Very few inhabited places on earth offer this from the back garden.

Where things are, in driving time

Across Invercargill

10 minutes, at any hour of any day.

→ Bluff

30 minutes south, for the oysters, the ferry and Stirling Point.

→ Riverton & Oreti Beach

15 to 40 minutes west along the coast.

→ Gore

1 hour north-east through the plains.

→ Te Anau & Fiordland

2 hours north-west. Milford Sound is around 4 hours from the city.

→ Dunedin / Queenstown

2 hr 15 and 2 hr respectively. Christchurch is 6 hours, or an hour in the air.

Words you'll hear

Murihiku Southland in te reo Māori – "the last joint of the tail".

Rakiura Stewart Island, across the strait from Bluff.

The burr The rolled Southland "r". The only real regional accent in the country.

Cheese rolls Grilled rolled bread with a cheese filling. A southern institution, not a joke.

Blue cod The local fish, and the correct order at any chippy south of Gore.

Bluff oysters Wild dredge oysters, in season roughly March to August. A genuine event.

Titī Muttonbird – a customary harvest on the islands off Rakiura.

The Stags Southland's provincial rugby side. Support is not optional.

The short version

A green farming plain with Fiordland at one end and the Southern Ocean at the other. The climate is cool, changeable and windy – that is the honest cost, and it is why the housing is the cheapest in the country. In return you get summer evenings that last until ten and wilderness most people see once in a lifetime. [Where clinicians live](#) is next.

Healthcare in Southland

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This is the chapter that separates Southland from the other far-south options. Unlike Central Otago, this region has a base hospital – and that single fact changes what a career here can look like.

The shape of the service

Public hospital and specialist services are delivered by Health New Zealand | Te Whatu Ora. The base hospital in Invercargill serves the whole region – roughly a hundred thousand people spread over an area larger than Wales – carrying acute medicine and surgery, an emergency department, intensive care, maternity, paediatrics, imaging, and a full outpatient and day-procedure service.

Beyond the city, care runs through a rural network: community and district services across the plains, and rural facilities in the northern and western districts serving Gore, the Te Anau basin, Fiordland and Rakiura. Distance is a live clinical factor. Retrieval and transfer – by road, and by air from Te Anau and the island – are a normal part of the working year.

Complex and highly specialised work is referred to Dunedin, two and a quarter hours away, and to Christchurch for some tertiary services. That relationship is close and well established.

ONE BASE HOSPITAL, AND THE COUNTRY BEHIND IT

A hundred thousand people spread over an area larger than Wales. The base hospital is what separates Southland from the other far-south options – and the rural network is what makes the work distinctive.

The region

Acute medicine and surgery, emergency, intensive care, maternity, paediatrics and imaging sit in the city; beyond it, community and district services across the plains, and rural facilities serving the north, the west and the island.

Invercargill · the base hospital Gore & the plains Te Anau & Fiordland Rakiura

And beyond it

Complex and highly specialised work is referred to Dunedin, two and a quarter hours away, with Christchurch used for some tertiary services. That relationship is close and well established.

Invercargill Dunedin · 2 hr 15

Retrieval and transfer – by road, and by air from Te Anau and the island – are a normal part of the working year, alongside search-and-rescue interaction and a tourism injury load from the Great Walks and the sounds.

What the work is like

Real hospital breadth

A base hospital in a region with no competing centre means you see everything the region produces. Scope is wide and referral options are further away, so you make more of the decisions.

Rural and remote reach

Fiordland, Rakiura and the western districts. Genuinely remote medicine, search-and-rescue interaction, and a tourism injury load from the Great Walks and the sounds.

A strong agricultural caseload

Farming is the region's economy, and farm injury, occupational health and rural mental health are a real and distinctive part of the work.

An ageing, dispersed population

Age-related medicine, orthopaedics and chronic disease weigh heavily, with access and distance compounding them across the plains.

Progression, sooner

A mid-sized service a long way from a tertiary centre gives you visibility and responsibility earlier than a large hospital would. Several clinicians we've placed here have stepped up faster than they expected.

Recruitment is the standing challenge

Southland has worked hard to attract and keep clinicians for years. That means genuine openness to international staff — and, honestly, some gaps and pressure alongside it.

Working with te ao Māori

This is the rohe of Ngāi Tahu, and Murihiku has a long history of settlement, harvest and trade along the southern coast and the islands. Iwi-led health providers are an established part of care delivery, and the region's health equity picture — rural, dispersed, with real access barriers and a significant Māori and Pacific population in the city — is central to the work rather than adjacent to it.

Practically: karakia at the start of meetings, te reo used on the ward, whānau involved in decisions. You are not expected to arrive fluent — you are expected to try. The national chapter **Te ao Māori at work** covers pronunciation, the words you will hear and marae etiquette.

What to ask at interview

What is the catchment for my service, and how much rural, outreach or island work is involved?

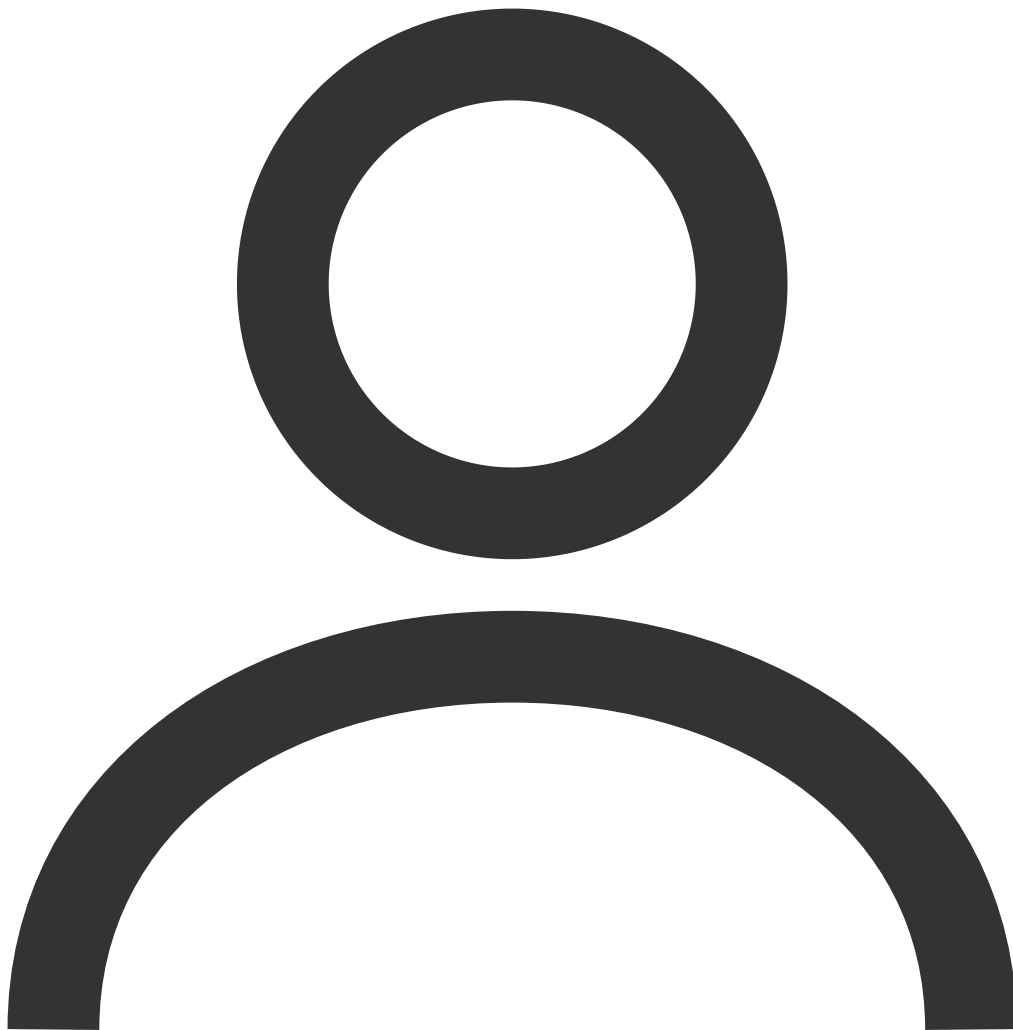
What is the on-call or rostered-hours pattern, and how is it paid under the relevant collective agreement?

What gets referred to Dunedin or Christchurch in my specialty, and what is my role in stabilising and transferring?

What orientation, supervision and cultural induction is there for clinicians new to New Zealand?

What professional development and study support exists, given the distance from a tertiary centre?

Is there relocation support, and what help is there finding housing and schools?



Sophie

Sophie's insight

Nobody asks me about Southland, and it is the region where I have seen people build the most life the fastest. A base hospital, a house bought outright within a few years, and Fiordland two hours away. The weather is the honest cost — everything else is in your favour.

Sophie Careem Founder, Ethicare Resourcing

Before you can start

Registration with your professional body, and the visa that goes with it, are national processes and identical wherever in New Zealand you land. They are explained once, properly, in [Eligibility & registration](#) and [Immigration & visas](#).

How the health system is funded and structured – ACC (accident cover for everyone, no fault attached), primary care, what things cost, how it differs from the NHS or a private system – lives in [How the health system works](#).

Ethicare

Live roles & professions



What we're recruiting for now, by profession and by region.

Nearby



The tertiary centre and medical school this region refers to, two and a quarter hours east.

Where clinicians live

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Invercargill is a city of wide streets and generous sections where every suburb is ten minutes from the hospital. That removes the usual trade-off entirely, so this chapter is about character and about how far out of the city you want to be.

THREE WAYS TO LIVE AT THE BOTTOM OF THE COUNTRY

Every city suburb sits within about ten minutes of the hospital, so the real choice runs on character and distance from town rather than the morning drive.

The city grid

Room to breathe on big flat sections, from villa streets near Queens Park to the value-heavy southern edges – New Zealand's cheapest city housing, minutes from work.

The bush fringe

Otatara's tree-wrapped blocks between city and estuary – land, trees and birdsong, ten minutes out.

The coast towns

Bluff on its hill half an hour south, Riverton at its river mouth forty minutes west – small-town character bought with a modest daily drive.

Whatever you pick, a family home on a single clinical salary is realistic here in a way it is almost nowhere else in the country.

In Invercargill

Waikiwi & Grasmere

Established northern suburbs, well regarded and well served by schools. A common landing spot for relocating clinical families, and close to the hospital.

Windsor & Georgetown

Solid, central, family housing on the eastern side. Good value even by local standards, and walkable to schools and shops.

Avenal & Gladstone

Older character housing near Queens Park, the city's large and lovely botanic park. Villas and bungalows, mature trees.

Rosedale & Newfield

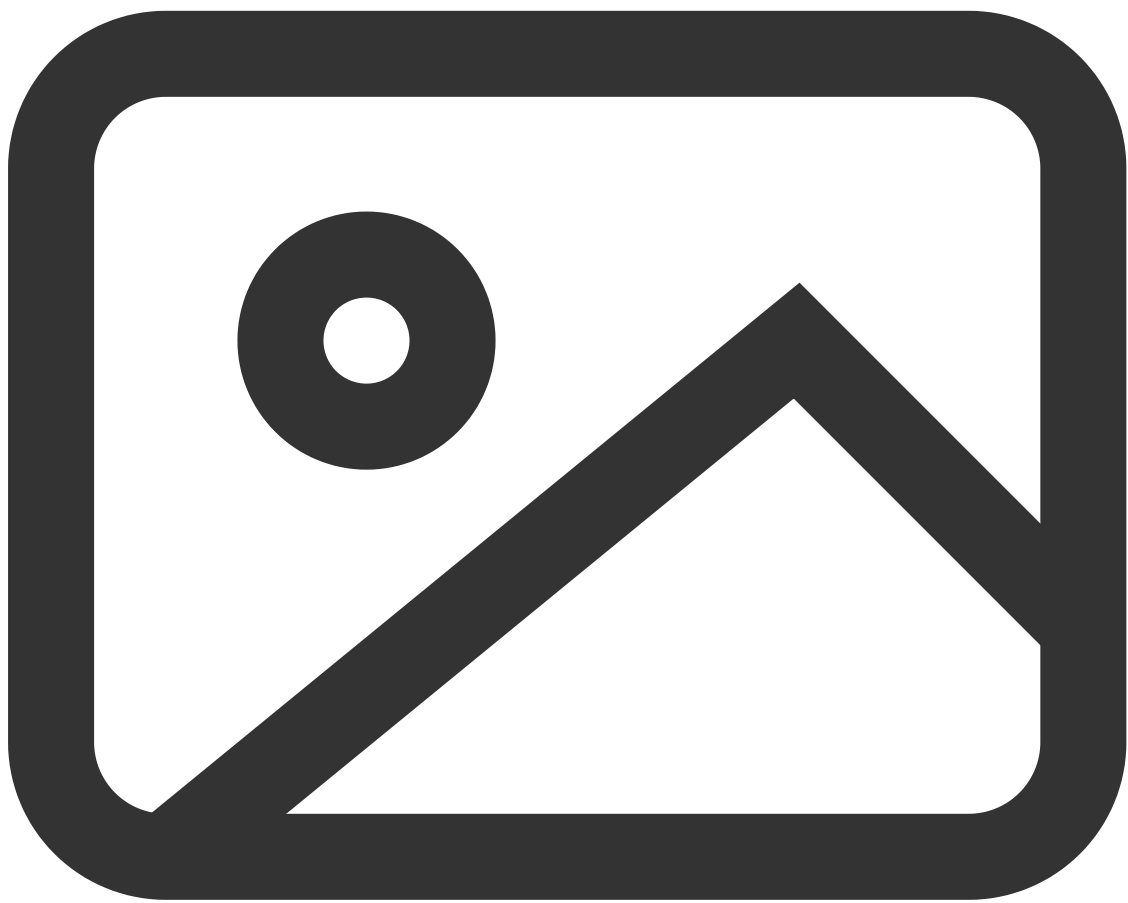
Affordable, straightforward suburbs on the southern and eastern edges. The best value in an already cheap city.

The city centre

Compact, being steadily redeveloped, with apartments appearing. Practical if you want to walk everywhere and don't need a garden.

Otatara

Semi-rural lifestyle blocks in native bush between the city and the estuary, ten minutes out. Where people go for land and trees.



Photography needed – Invercargill housing

Wide streets, generous sections, established suburbs

The coast and the towns

Bluff

Thirty minutes south, on a hill above the strait. A working port town with real character, the oysters, and the ferry to Rakiura. Cheap, windy and much loved by those who choose it.

Riverton / Aparima

Forty minutes west, a small seaside town at a river mouth – arguably the prettiest spot in the region and increasingly popular. Beach, boats and a genuine community.

Winton

Half an hour north on the plains. A tidy farming service town with a school and a straightforward commute.

Gore

An hour north-east on the Maitai. The region's second town, with its own services, schooling and a strong identity – brown trout, country music and farming.

Fiordland

Te Anau

Two hours north-west, on the lake at the gateway to Fiordland National Park. A small town with a rural health service, a school, and the most spectacular setting in the country. Its own decision, not an Invercargill commute.

Rakiura / Stewart Island

An hour by ferry from Bluff. Four hundred people, eighty-five per cent national park, kiwi in the evening. A genuine remote-community posting for a very particular clinician.

Three things to check before you sign

Insulation, heating and ventilation. This is the cool, damp end of the country. The good news: houses are cheap enough that you can afford one already done properly. Ask for the Healthy Homes compliance statement.

Whether to rent at all. Unusually for this collection, buying quickly is realistic here. Many clinicians rent for six months to learn the city and then purchase – see [Cost of living](#).

The school zone, at the exact address. Choice is good for a city this size, and popular schools are zoned by address – see [Schools & education](#).

How renting works – the application pack, bond, tenancy rights and the Healthy Homes standards – is national and covered once in [Renting in New Zealand](#).

Cost of living

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Invercargill has the lowest house prices of any city in New Zealand, and it is not a narrow lead. On a clinical salary that is not a small convenience — it changes what your money is for.

Why there are no prices on this page

We used to print a weekly rent and a monthly budget table here. We have taken them out. A figure that was true when a page was written is misleading a year later, and a candidate who plans a move around a stale number is worse off than one who plans around none.

What does not go stale is the *shape* of a month, and the judgement about which lines will surprise you — which is what the rest of this chapter is for. For today's actual numbers use the calculators at the foot of the page, and use them to compare Southland against the city you are leaving. That is the only comparison that decides anything.

What the numbers actually mean

Clinical pay is national. You arrive on the same salary you would earn in Auckland, Queenstown or Wellington, into the country's cheapest housing market. There is no regional adjustment downward: you simply keep more of it.

Put concretely: a large four-bedroom family home on a proper section, ten minutes from the hospital, in a well-regarded school zone, costs a fraction of a modest apartment in Queenstown two hours north. Most clinicians we place in Southland buy within their first year or two, rather than renting for a decade while they save.

What that buys beyond the house is the interesting part. Clinicians here tend to travel more, work fewer extra shifts, and reach financial decisions years earlier than colleagues on identical pay elsewhere. That is the real proposition, and the weather is the price of it.

Renting, by area

Waikiwi, Grasmere & Windsor

The city's more sought-after family suburbs, and still modest by national standards. Where most relocating clinical families start.

Avenal & Gladstone

Character housing near Queens Park. Lovely streets, older homes – check the insulation carefully.

Rosedale & Newfield

The best value in an already cheap city. Straightforward family housing at prices that surprise everyone arriving from overseas.

Otatara

Lifestyle blocks in native bush, ten minutes out. Land and trees for a fraction of what they'd cost anywhere north.

Bluff, Riverton & Winton

Cheaper again, and coastal or rural with it. Riverton has firmed up as people discover it; Bluff remains the region's bargain.

Te Anau

The exception. Tourism demand and limited stock make Fiordland's gateway town markedly more expensive and tighter than the rest of the region.

WHERE A MONTH ACTUALLY GOES

The proportions, for one person on a mid-range budget. Proportions move slowly; prices move every quarter. Rent is forty-five per cent of it – the smallest share of any region in this collection.



Rent	45%
Groceries	20%
Car — petrol, insurance, running	11%
Power & water (winter-weighted)	10%
Entertainment & leisure	9%
Internet	4%
Mobile phone plan	2%

The line that decides it

Rent • 45%

Two lines run higher than the national pattern and both are honest: winter power, and a car you will genuinely need. They still do not come close to closing the gap the rent line opens.

Indicative prices that change over time. The rent line is the lowest in this collection, and the power line is among the highest — that trade is the whole story.

The costs particular to here

Winter heating

The genuine local cost. Cool, damp and dark for a good stretch, so a well-insulated home with proper heating matters. Because houses are cheap, buying one already sorted is realistic.

Getting home, and getting out

The longest travel day in the collection. If you'll fly to Europe or South Africa a few times a year, budget properly for it – and factor in the drive to Queenstown.

Good outdoor kit

A serious coat, boots and layers are not optional here. Nor is the gear if you intend to use Fiordland, which you will.

A car, and probably two

Essential across the region. The upside is that the money you're not spending on housing covers it comfortably.

Work out your own numbers

[Compare cities](#)

[Numbeo · cost of living](#)



Invercargill prices for rent, groceries, transport and dining, against your current city. Crowd-sourced, and the sample is thin for a place this size — treat it as a ballpark, not a quote.

(<https://www.numbeo.com/cost-of-living/in/Invercargill>)

Plan your budget

Sorted budget planner



New Zealand's free, government-backed budgeting tool.

(<https://sorted.org.nz/tools/budget-planner/>)

Official data



The Household Living-Costs Price Index, updated quarterly.

(<https://www.stats.govt.nz/topics/household-living-costs-price-indexes/>)

Property



Current Southland rentals and homes for sale. Compare against your current city and prepare to be surprised.

(<https://www.realestate.co.nz/residential/sale/southland>)

Sanity check



A cleaner side-by-side of two cities. Worth running when Numbeo looks off.

(<https://www.expatistan.com/cost-of-living>)

Official rents



Bond-lodgement data by area – the most reliable rent figure in New Zealand.

(<https://www.tenancy.govt.nz/rent-bond-and-bills/market-rent/>)

How pay, tax, IRD numbers, KiwiSaver and sending money home actually work is national and explained once in **Money, tax & banking**.

The honest summary

The cheapest city housing in New Zealand, on national clinical pay, with a base hospital ten minutes away. Most people here buy rather than rent, and sooner than they planned. The costs are winter heating and the distance home – both real, and both smaller than what you're saving.

Getting around

Southland Guide · Chapter 6 of 9

Getting around inside Southland is the easiest of any region in this collection. Getting out of it is the hardest. Both are worth understanding before you commit.

The commute

Ten minutes across Invercargill, at any hour. The city was laid out on a generous grid with wide streets, and the traffic never arrived to fill them. Parking is free and abundant, including at the hospital. There is no rush hour to speak of.

If you are arriving from a large city, this is the change you will feel every single day. Clinicians tell us the reclaimed time is the thing they would least want to give back.

Beyond the city

The plains

Straight, quiet, well-sealed roads through farmland. Winton half an hour, Gore an hour, and almost no traffic on any of it.

The coast road

West to Riverton and the Catlins east – the Southern Scenic Route. Slower, winding and worth taking for its own sake.

The Fiordland road

Two hours north-west to Te Anau, then the Milford road beyond it – one of the great drives anywhere, and subject to avalanche closures in winter.

Winter conditions

Frost and fog rather than deep snow at sea level. Black ice on the plains at dawn is the real hazard, and the Milford road is the one to check properly.

Wildlife on the road

Genuinely a factor at dawn and dusk on rural roads. Slow down.

Do you need a car?

Yes. There is a city bus network in Invercargill and it is useful, but the region assumes a vehicle and most households run two.

The ferry to Rakiura

From Bluff, thirty minutes south of the city, a passenger ferry crosses Foveaux Strait to Oban on Stewart Island in about an hour. There are also light aircraft from Invercargill Airport, which take twenty minutes and are often the better option in poor weather.

Worth knowing: Foveaux Strait has a reputation, and it earns it. The crossing can be genuinely rough. If you plan to work or travel to the island regularly, the flight is what most people end up doing.

Flying

Invercargill Airport

Ten minutes from the city, with regular flights to Christchurch and Auckland, and light aircraft to Rakiura.

Queenstown, two hours

The nearest airport with direct trans-Tasman flights. A number of Southlanders drive up for international travel, and it is a straightforward run.

Long-haul

Via Christchurch or Auckland, or a drive to Queenstown. This is the longest travel day of any region in this guide, and it is fair to weigh that.

Getting home

Budget a full day at each end. If you'll be travelling to Europe or Africa several times a year, factor it in properly.

Distances worth knowing

Journey	Typical time
Across Invercargill	10 min
City → airport	10 min
City → Oreti Beach	15 min
City → Bluff	30 min
City → Winton	30 min
City → Riverton	40 min
City → Gore	1 hr
City → Te Anau	2 hr
City → Queenstown	2 hr
City → Dunedin	2 hr 15
City → Milford Sound	~4 hr
City → Christchurch	6 hr, or 1 hr 15 flying
Bluff → Oban, Rakiura	1 hr by ferry, 20 min by air

Times on dry roads. Add for frost and fog in winter, and always check the Milford road before setting out.

Converting your licence, buying a car, and what a warrant of fitness and registration involve are national matters, explained once in [Driving & licences](#).

Food, shopping & the everyday

Southland Guide · Chapter 8 of 9

Southland has a stronger food identity than any region in this collection, and almost none of it is fashionable. It comes from the sea, the farms and a hundred and fifty years of Scottish stubbornness, and locals are unembarrassed about all of it.

What comes out of the water

Bluff oysters are the region's great annual event. Wild dredge oysters from Foveaux Strait, in season roughly March to August, and by common agreement among the best in the world. There is a festival, there are queues, and there is a genuine local calendar built around the opening.

Blue cod is the local fish and the correct order at any chippy in the region. **Crayfish**, pāua and mussels come off the same coast, and **tītī** — muttonbird — remains a customary harvest on the islands off Rakiura, sold locally in season and an acquired taste that Southlanders are pleased to watch you acquire.

And **cheese rolls**: rolled bread with a cheese and onion-soup filling, grilled. Every café, every fundraiser, every school gala. Do not describe them as a novelty in front of a local.

What comes off the land

Southland is intensively farmed dairy and sheep country, and the produce reflects it. Local lamb and beef, exceptional dairy, and a real culture of home baking and preserving that has survived here better than in the cities. Gore is brown-trout capital and takes that seriously too.

The farmers' markets in Invercargill and Gore cover produce, meat and baking. Between them and the coast you can eat extremely well from within fifty kilometres, and cheaply.

Eating out and the everyday

Invercargill

A modest but improving scene — good cafés, a handful of strong restaurants, craft beer, and the best-value eating out in the country. The city centre has been steadily redeveloped.

Riverton & Bluff

Small coastal spots punching above their weight, particularly for seafood. Where locals take visitors.

Te Anau

Tourism-facing and better than you'd expect for the size, with prices to match the visitor market.

Groceries

All the main chains, and prices at or below the national average. Food in New Zealand is expensive by British or Australian standards – that is national, and this is the cheapest place in the country to deal with it.

Specialist and imported ingredients are the honest weak point. There are Asian and Indian grocers in Invercargill and the range is better than the city's size suggests, but it is narrower than any of the main centres. If a particular cuisine is central to how your family eats, check before you commit – the national chapter [Finding your feet & your people](#) covers where to look and which communities are established here.

The rhythm of the year

Summer is lived outdoors, late

Light until nearly ten. Barbecues at nine, cricket, the beach, the estuary. Four months of the year the evenings are enormous.

Winter is lived indoors, well

Dark and damp, and the region has responded with unusually good indoor facilities for its size – pools, gyms, a velodrome, indoor sport and a strong club culture.

Sport and motorsport are the social glue

Rugby first, but also netball, cycling, hockey, and a serious motorsport tradition. Joining a club is by far the fastest way to know people properly.

Newcomers are noticed, and welcomed

A small city that has worked hard to attract people tends to look after the ones who arrive.

Southland hospitality is not a marketing line.

Honest limitations

Retail is functional. Serious shopping means Dunedin, Christchurch or online, and delivery takes a day or two longer than up north.

Touring music, theatre and major exhibitions mostly stop at Dunedin or Christchurch.

Specialist imported groceries are limited. Most people build up a Dunedin or Christchurch order a few times a year.

Fiordland, Rakiura & the south coast

Southland Guide · Chapter 9 of 9

This is the answer to every reservation in this guide. Two hours from your front door is one of the great wildernesses on earth. An hour by sea is an island that is almost entirely national park. And the coast between them is emptier than anywhere else you will live.

THE WILDERNESS, FROM YOUR FRONT DOOR

Driving times from Invercargill, to scale against each other. The marked row is the answer to every reservation in this guide: World Heritage wilderness begins two hours from home.

Oreti Beach

Firm open sand for kilometres, and cars are allowed on it



~15 min

Bluff & Stirling Point

Land's end: the harbour hill walk and the famous local catch



~30 min

Riverton & the western coast

A small seaside town where the coast road turns west



~40 min

Te Anau & the edge of Fiordland

Where the road ends and the World Heritage area starts



~2 hours

Milford Sound

The drive is the event – at its best in heavy rain



~4 hours

Rakiura / Stewart Island sits off this chart entirely – a short ferry crossing or a lighter flight, and close enough that it needs no annual leave.

Fiordland

1.2 million hectares of World Heritage wilderness, beginning about two hours north-west of the city. Glacier-carved sounds, rainforest, waterfalls and some of the highest rainfall on the planet. Most New Zealanders visit once. You would live at the edge of it.

Milford Sound

About four hours from the city on one of the great drives anywhere. Go on a wet day – that is when the waterfalls are extraordinary and the buses are fewer.

Doubtful Sound

Larger, quieter and harder to reach, via Lake Manapouri. Overnight trips are worth doing once and then again.

The Milford Track

Booked out a year ahead by people flying from the other side of the world. You would be two hours from the start.

The Kepler & Routeburn

Two more Great Walks within easy reach of Te Anau, and a lifetime of shorter tracks around them.

Te Anau & Manapouri

Lakeside towns that make a good weekend base, and a glowworm cave under the lake.

Takahē and kākāpō country

Some of the rarest birds on earth live in and off this coast. Conservation here is a live, visible thing.

Rakiura / Stewart Island

An hour by ferry from Bluff, or twenty minutes by light aircraft. Four hundred people, eighty-five per cent national park, and one of the best places in the world to see kiwi in the wild – genuinely, walking on a beach at dusk. There is the Rakiura Track for three days, day walks from Oban, Ulva Island's bird sanctuary, and a night sky with almost no light pollution in it.

Southlanders treat it as a long weekend rather than an expedition. That is a remarkable thing to be able to say about a place like this.

The coast and the plains

Oreti Beach

Fifteen minutes from the city – a vast grey sweep of sand you can drive on, and where Burt Munro tested his motorcycle. Bracing rather than tropical, and often empty.

Bluff & Stirling Point

The signpost at the bottom of the country, the hill walk above the port, and the oysters. Thirty minutes south.

Riverton & the western coast

Forty minutes west. A river-mouth town, beaches, and the start of the road towards Fiordland's southern edge.

The Catlins

East along the Southern Scenic Route – waterfalls, a petrified forest, penguins, sea lions and Nugget Point. One of the best day trips in New Zealand.

The rivers

The Mataura and Oreti are internationally known brown-trout water. Gore does not let you forget it.

The aurora australis

On clear, active nights, from the southern horizon. There are local groups who watch for it, and it is one of the genuine privileges of living this far south.

Further afield

Queenstown – 2 hr

Four ski fields, the lakes and the restaurants, without paying to live there.

Central Otago – 2 hr 30

The wine, the rail trail and the autumn. See the Central Otago guide.

Dunedin – 2 hr 15

The nearest city, for galleries, gigs, the peninsula's albatross and penguin colonies, and a change of pace.

The Mackenzie & Aoraki – 5 hr

Mount Cook, Lake Tekapo and the dark-sky reserve, for a longer weekend.

Useful links

Tourism



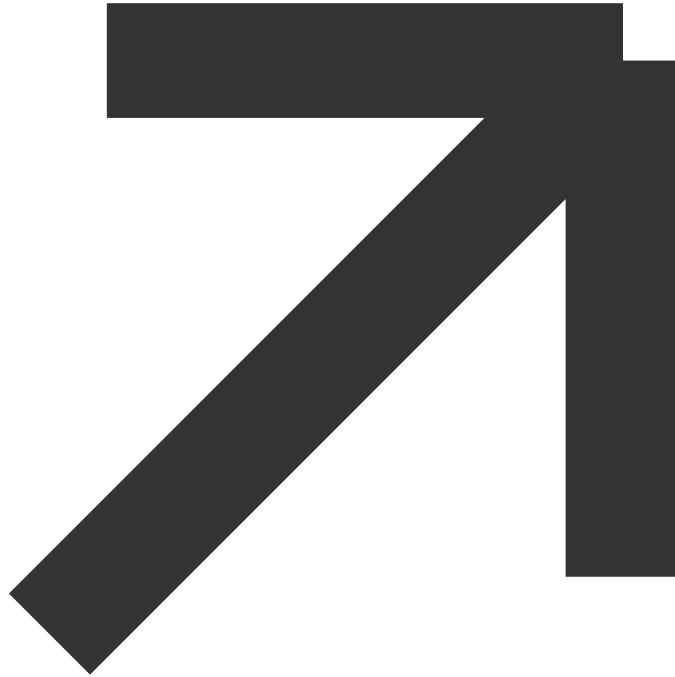
The region's official visitor site: the coast, the towns, events and the scenic route.
Fiordland



Te Anau, Manapouri, Milford and Doubtful Sound — what to do and when to go.
Outdoors



Great Walks, huts, bookings and alerts for Fiordland and Rakiura.
Council



Local services, pools, libraries, parks and community programmes.

That's the guide

Nine chapters on Southland. Everything national – visas, registration, tax, renting, driving, schools, te ao Māori – lives in [Moving to New Zealand](#). This is the region people overlook and then quietly recommend to everyone. When you'd like to talk it through, [we're here](#), with no pressure and no pipeline.